free 2012 by-elections and the apparent acceptance of the NLD as a legitimate opposition was that Myanmar became chair of ASEAN in 2014 for the first time. However, the 2015 refugee crisis (discussed in the next chapter) led to a breakdown in relations. In effect, Myanmar's policies were threatening the security of other states, and Malaysia in particular firmly placed the blame for the crisis on Myanmar's treatment of the Rohingyas. The criticisms were direct, and included demands for the Rohingyas to be granted citizenship.[131] Myanmar, perhaps not surprisingly, refused, and its relations with ASEAN have reverted to being limited to attendance at formal meetings.

Myanmar's interactions with ASEAN are perhaps indicative of its wider approach to international relations. As a group, ASEAN is worried about China's rise to regional dominance: while they welcome the trade and economic development opportunities, they fear the spread of Chinese power.[132] On a number of occasions, Myanmar has traded on this fear when ASEAN places it under pressure. In effect, Myanmar has forced ASEAN to minimise criticism on the grounds that this will drive the regime to become less dependent on its ASEAN links and more reliant on China.[133]

This indicates that the regime may well like to have multiple partners and is not worried if they have conflicting goals. If China and the US were not competing with one another in Myanmar, one or the other might be more willing to take steps to criticise the regime and perhaps punish it for ongoing human rights abuses. North Korea in this sense is an ideal bargaining card. It provides something very useful to the regime (arms sales), and its influence can be used as an implicit threat to all of the US, India and China—in effect, can they risk antagonising the Myanmar regime if it will then turn to a closer link with North Korea?

The shifts in international relations reflect a convenient narrative available to Western leaders. Myanmar is on the road to some form of democracy, the economy is open for foreign investment and there is a media-friendly opposition leader available. Myanmar is now seen as an opportunity and many states, both regional and international, are keen to exploit the mineral wealth of the country.[134] And whatever problems we see today, they can be dismissed as nothing more than bumps along the road as Myanmar moves towards democracy, liberalism and Western values.

Thein Sein has clearly benefitted from his apparently reformist policies. *Foreign Policy* named him 'Thinker of the Year' in 2012, and UN